natHacks 2026



NATHACKS 2026

HACKER HANDBOOK

NOVEMBER 6–9, 2026

DONADEO INNOVATION CENTRE FOR ENGINEERING, UNIVERSITY OF ALBERTA

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WELCOME & KEY INFO

WELCOME TO NATHACKS 2026!

natHacks 2026 is a 64-hour competition where teams design, build, and pitch solutions across Healthcare & Accessibility, Defense & Security, and Construction & Manufacturing.

Thank you for spending your weekend with us and being part of the NAT community. We hope you leave with new connections, valuable experience, and something you are proud to have built!

EVENT DATES & MAIN VENUE

November 6–9, 2026
DICE, 8th Floor, University of Alberta • 9211 116 St NW, Edmonton

COMMUNICATION PLATFORM ↗

The **natHacks 2026 Discord** is our central communication platform for announcements, updates, questions, and support. Check it regularly throughout the event.

NEED HELP?

Check the **natHacks FAQ**, visit the check-in desk near the DICE 8th floor elevators, or ask us in **#hacker-support** on Discord.

EVENT OVERVIEW

VIEW THE FULL SCHEDULE ↗

KICKOFF SESSIONS	Oct 23 & 30, 2026 1:30–7:30 PM	Workshops and networking to help hackers build skills and prepare for natHacks.
CHECK-IN & NATWORKING MIXER	Nov 6, 2026 3:00–5:00 PM	Hacker check-in, networking, and exhibitor booths with community partners.
OPENING CEREMONY	Nov 6, 2026 6:30–7:00 PM	Official welcome and overview of competition rules, schedules, prizes, and resources.
64-HOUR COMPETITION	Nov 6, 7:00 PM – Nov 9, 11:00 AM	Teams have 64 hours to develop and build prototypes, with access to hardware and advisors.
JUDGING & CLOSING CEREMONY	Nov 9, 2026 12:00–6:00 PM	Project presentations and judging, followed by the finalist showcase, awards, and closing ceremony.



BEFORE NATHACKS

JOIN THE DISCORD ↗

Discord is used as the central communication channel for natHacks. We will verify that you have joined the Discord at check-in.

DIVISION-SPECIFIC TASKS

Standard Division: Form a team of 4-6 through the Team Creation Form by Nov 6 at 11:59 PM MDT. Need inspiration? See our list of 100+ Project Ideas.

Problem Provider Division: Submit all Development Reports by Nov 6 at 11:59 PM MDT to earn bonus judging points.

Pre-event planning is allowed, but all coding and prototyping must take place during natHacks.

WHAT TO BRING

Bring your laptop and charger and a refillable water bottle. If you're 18+ with a confirmed overnight RSVP, bring a pillow, blanket, toiletries, towel, shower shoes, and extra clothes.

VENUE & ARRIVAL

NOV 6: CHECK-IN & MIXER

When you arrive on Friday, November 6, head to the **ETLC Solarium** (9120 116 St NW, Edmonton) for **check-in and the NATworking Mixer from 3–5 PM**, followed by dinner from 5–6 PM.

MAIN VENUE

The main competition space is on the 8th floor of DICE at the University of Alberta (9211 116 St NW, Edmonton). Teams are free to use any available open seating. Meeting rooms must be booked in advance using the **Room Booking Instructions**.

VENUE HOURS & ACCESS

The main venue is available to participants ages 18+ from Nov 6 at 3 PM until Nov 9 at 7 PM, including overnight. Sleeping accommodations require a confirmed RSVP (see pg. 7).
Participants under 18 must leave the venue by 10 PM each night.

Hours: DICE doors are open Monday–Friday, 7:30 AM–5:30 PM, and closed on weekends. The ETLC east doors are open Monday–Friday, 7 AM–7 PM, and weekends, 9 AM–4 PM. After hours, ONEcard holders can access the east doors until 10 PM on weekdays and 8 PM on weekends.

Parking: Paid parking is available at Windsor Car Park, located at 116 Street and 92 Avenue.

If you can't access the building during the event, post your location in the #locked-out channel on Discord and an organizer on site will let you in.

CONDUCT & SAFETY

NATHACKS CODE OF CONDUCT ↗

Treat others with respect and keep the venue and shared equipment in good condition.

Harassment, discrimination, unsafe or disruptive behaviour, plagiarism, submitting pre-event work, theft, and property damage are prohibited. Alcohol, illegal drugs, and smoking/vaping are not permitted at the venue or during event activities.

Violating the Code of Conduct may result in removal from the event.

HEALTH & SUPPORT

Take regular breaks, stay hydrated, eat, and get enough sleep throughout the event. **If you feel unwell, reach out to an organizer.**



EMERGENCIES & SAFETY

In an emergency, call 911, then notify NAT. For a fire evacuation, meet at Engineering Quad. To report non-emergency safety incidents, call University of Alberta Protective Services any time at 780-492-5050. Know the emergency exits. See the full safety policy for more information.

natHacks 2026

SCHEDULE

	6	7	8	9
9 AM		9 AM Breakfast 10 AM	9 AM Breakfast 10 AM	9 AM Breakfast 10 AM
10 AM				Project Submissions Due 11 AM
11 AM				11 AM Lunch 12 PM
12 PM				12 PM Presentations + Judging 3 PM
1 PM		1 PM Lunch 2 PM	1 PM Lunch 2 PM	
2 PM				
3 PM	3 PM Check-in & Networking 5 PM			3 PM Break + Snack 4 PM
4 PM				4 PM Finalist Showcase + Closing Ceremony 6 PM
5 PM	5 PM Dinner 6 PM			
6 PM	6:30 PM Opening 7 PM	6 PM Dinner 7 PM	6 PM Dinner 7 PM	
7 PM	Hacking Begins			
8 PM				

NOVEMBER 6–9, 2026

STAYING OVERNIGHT

(AGES 18+, RSVP REQUIRED)

Sleeping areas are in the **ETLC Solarium**: East (men) and West (women and gender-diverse participants).

Sleeping Area Hours: 9 PM–9 AM each night, Nov 6–9.

HOW TO RSVP

To stay overnight, you must be 18 or older, complete the Overnight RSVP Form by Nov 5 at 11:59 PM MDT, and receive confirmation by email.

Eligible out-of-town participants who RSVP by the deadline are guaranteed space. Edmonton participants are accommodated on a first-come, first-served basis. Bring your own pillow and blanket.

RULES & SAFETY ↗

Quiet hours begin at **11 PM**. Follow the natHacks Code of Conduct and safety guidelines. You are responsible for your belongings. Clear your sleeping space by **9 AM**.

Read the Overnight Info Sheet for full details and rules.

SHOWERS

Showers are available at the Van Vliet Complex during drop-in swimming hours.

YOUR TEAM & ROLES

TEAM FORMATION

Standard Division: Form your own team of 4-6 and complete the emailed Team Formation Form by Nov 6 at 11:59 PM MDT. **Looking for teammates?** Connect through Discord or at the NATworking Mixer on Nov 6.

Problem Provider Division: Teams have been assigned by NAT and sent through email. Use your private Discord channel to communicate with your teammates and Problem Provider.

ROLES & RESPONSIBILITIES

Each team must select a leader, who will serve as the main point of contact with organizers.

Divide up tasks based on each person's skills and interests. Roles can overlap, but everyone should have clear responsibilities.



ADVISORS



AREAS OF EXPERTISE

Advisors are available to help teams with hardware, software, AI, research, problem-solving, project planning, business strategy, and pitching.

HOW TO ACCESS ADVISORS

Advisors will be walking around the DICE 8th floor, so feel free to approach them directly.

You can also request help in **#advisor-requests** on Discord. Include your team name, location, and what you need help with.

VIEW THE ADVISOR SCHEDULE ↗

Check the **Advisor Schedule** for advising times, bios, and areas of expertise.

HARDWARE PICKUP

Visit the Hardware Desk (DICE 8-292) to borrow kits, sensors, and accessories. Requests submitted through the emailed hardware form are prioritized by submission time.

Teams with confirmed reservations can collect their items during **reserved pickup**. Remaining hardware is available during **general pickup** on a first-come, first-served basis, while supplies last.

HARDWARE DESK HOURS

NOV 6	**Reserved pickup:** 5:30–6:30 PM **General pickup**: 7 PM–9 PM
NOV 7–8	10 AM–9 PM
NOV 9	**All hardware must be returned by 7 PM on Nov 9**

HARDWARE RULES & RETURNS

Only the team leader may sign out hardware. Teams are responsible for all borrowed items, which must be returned in original condition. Report any equipment issues, missing items, or damage to the Hardware Desk immediately.

VIEW AVAILABLE HARDWARE ↗

PROJECT SUBMISSIONS

HOW TO SUBMIT

Teams must submit their completed project by Nov 9 at 11:00 AM MDT using the form shared on Discord. **Late submissions will not be accepted.**

All team members must participate in judging unless their absence has been excused by NAT organizers in advance.

SUBMISSION REQUIREMENTS

PROJECT SUMMARY	Briefly explain the problem, approach, and results. Max 250 words.
ABOUT THE PROJECT	Briefly explain what inspired your team, what your team learned, how you built your project, and the challenges you faced. Max 600 words.
CODE REPOSITORY	Code must be solely developed during the 64-hour natHacks weekend. Include a README file explaining your project, how to access or run it, and any supporting materials (e.g., slides, links, and credits)
5-MINUTE PRESENTATION & DEMO	Teams may include a video in their live demo, as long as it fits within the presentation time. A 5-minute Q&A will follow.

EVALUATION

VIEW THE FULL RUBRIC ↗

CATEGORY	DESCRIPTION	MAX
Technical Execution & Problem-Solving	Quality of the technical approach, decisions, integration, and problem-solving demonstrated.	**10**
Prototype Functionality & Usability	How well the prototype works and supports the needs of its intended users.	**10**
Creativity & Innovation	Originality of the solution and how effectively it approaches the problem in a new way.	**10**
Impact & Real-World Relevance	Importance of the problem and the solution's potential to provide meaningful real-world value.	**10**
Feasibility & Continuation Potential	Practicality of the solution and the strength of the plan for further development or implementation.	**10**
Pitch & Demonstration	Clarity and effectiveness of the presentation, demonstration, and responses to Judge questions.	**10**
Written Summary	Clarity and completeness of the team's written explanation of its problem, approach, and results.	**5**
Division-Specific Bonus	Team composition in SD or use of Development Reports in PPD.	**3**

PRIZES

PRIZE FUNDING & ELIGIBILITY

All monetary prizes are provided as **reimbursement-based funding** for expenses related to further developing the winning project. Funding is available for up to **nine months** after winners are announced.

Review the official rules to confirm your team's prize eligibility.

PRIZE STRUCTURE

Standard Division: 1st, 2nd, and 3rd place prizes are awarded in each of the three themes: Healthcare & Accessibility, Defense & Security, and Construction & Manufacturing.

Problem Provider Division: 1st, 2nd, and 3rd place prizes are awarded across the division as a whole.

1ST
$2,000 CAD seed funding +
$2,000 CAD in-kind services

2ND
$1,000 CAD seed funding +
$1,000 CAD in-kind services

3RD
$500 CAD seed funding +
$500 CAD in-kind services

First-place teams will be invited to present a 1-minute pitch during the Closing Ceremony.

ORGANIZING TEAM

LOGISTICS

Evy Redman
Jaytegan Singh Sawhney (JT)
Shreya Ghosh
Jihoon Og

MARKETING & DESIGN

Shula Juguilon
Hana Kasahun-Melke
Franz Pechardo

STAKEHOLDER ENGAGEMENT

Scott Gerke
Helen Wu
James Castro

HARDWARE & TECH

Hiritikk Kumar
Saachi Gupta
Zach Selk



OUR PARTNERS

Alberta Government

Canada
National Research Council Canada
Conseil national de recherches Canada

UNIVERSITY OF ALBERTA

TECHNATION CA

CAREER READY PROGRAM

Elko ENGINEERING GARAGE

Canadian Bioinformatics Hub
powered by Bioinformatics.ca

AIESEC

Alberta Government

Through the NRED Grant program, the **Government of Alberta** supports organizations that drive economic growth, workforce development, and innovation across the province. Their efforts help create jobs, provide sustainable opportunities, and ensure Alberta stays competitive in a global market.

National Research Council Canada | Conseil national de recherches Canada

The National Research Council of Canada develops scientific discoveries into solutions that make real impact. Through cutting-edge research, specialized facilities, and collaboration with businesses, researchers, and innovators, the NRC tackles some of Canada's biggest challenges.

TECHNATION CA | CAREER READY PROGRAM

TECHNATION's Career Ready program connects post-secondary students with hands-on work experience and employers across Canada's tech sector. By helping students build practical skills and industry connections, TECHNATION supports the next generation of digital talent and strengthens Canada's innovation economy.



UNIVERSITY OF ALBERTA

The **Engineering Incubator** at U of A's Engineering Teaching & Learning Complex supports early-stage tech ventures by providing mentorship, prototyping space, and programming for student innovators.

The **Office of the Vice-President (Innovation, Knowledge Mobilization and Partnerships)** drives the University of Alberta's research and innovation enterprise, supporting excellence, partnerships, and compliance with the highest ethical and operational standards.

The **Department of Biomedical Engineering** conducts research spanning bionics, biomechanics, precision health design, advanced imaging, nanomedicine, and bioengineering. The department's programs combine rigorous academics with hands-on research training in leading-edge biomedical environments.